

SCRIPT TITLE

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INT. DETECTIVE'S OFFICE - DAY

LUCILE, a woman in a nebulous time of early-mid womanhood sits clacking away at a typewriter.

A MAN stands further inside the office listening to the bass. Tapping along, maybe snapping a little. He's a hulking mass, dressed in a fine, wide-shouldered suit.

STANLEY C. CLARKE enters in a huff and stops at Lucile's desk.

Stan doesn't initially see the man. He first addresses Lucile.

STANLEY
Landlord's dog got out again,
Lucile.
(beat)
Chased me damn near three blocks!

LUCILE
That must explain the odor, Mr.
Clarke!

Lucile waves her hand in front of her nose. Backing up in her seat ever so slightly.

STANLEY
Sure got the blood flowing.
(beat)
I don't think I'll need coffee
today!

LUCILE
Speak for yourself!

Lucile eye rolls back to typing on her typewriter.

LUCILE (CONT'D)
(while typing)
The lieutenant let himself in
again.

Stan's shoulders drop, he looks to the ground then to Lucile.

STANLEY
I think I'm gonna need that coffee.

Stanley enters his office. The man doesn't turn, he keeps tapping his foot.

Stan throws his jacket on his chair, sits and gets situated behind his desk.

He attempts numerous postures and positions at his desk before saying anything. He gesticulates as he's about to begin, stops, then attempts again, until:

MAN

Late again!

The man turns.

MAN (CONT'D)

And I can smell you from here.

(beat)

Jesus man, did you run here?

STANLEY

Yeah. For a stretch.

Stanley repositions and points a finger at his visitor.

STANLEY (CONT'D)

You know, you could use a few laps yourself, Mo.

MAN

That's Lieutenant Maurice Callahan to you, Stanley.

The moment is tense.

Stanley throws his arms in the air then behind his head and stares down Maurice.

Maurice releases a deep belly laugh.

Stanley instantly disarms and pulls out glasses and a bottle of bourbon.

STANLEY

Will you ever stop pulling rank,
dill weed?

Stanley pours two stiff drinks.

MAURICE

Will you ever leave the schoolyard?

Maurice sits.

STANLEY

Those were my finest days!

(beat)

You certainly weren't complaining
about all those answer keys I
acquired for you.

MAURICE

Well, you're lucky we have a use
for degenerates like yourself.

(beat)

That's why I'm here.

(beat)

Something's gone missing.

(beat)

Something dangerous in the wrong
hands.

(beat)

Ever heard of Acute Vibrio
Pneumococcal Pan-sepsis.

STANLEY

Pan-whatsis?

MAURICE

In short!

(beat)

The plague.

Stan's eyes go wide, his glass returns to the desk.

STANLEY

Oh wow, you should **not** have lost
that!

Maurice grows agitated, then calms himself.

MAURICE

We intend this loss of possession
to be a temporary issue.

(beat)

That's where you come in.

Stanley recoils in his chair.

STANLEY

Woah, hey, I haven't got all my
shots.

(shouting)

In fact, I think Lucile might...

LUCILE

(over her shoulder)

Nope, all up to date, Mr. C!

Stanley snaps in disappointment.

MAURICE

No is not an available option for
you, Stan.

(beat)

(MORE)

MAURICE (CONT'D)
Your government needs you to track
down a kraut.

Stan gets up and walks to the edge of his desk.

STANLEY
The Germans. Damn.

MAURICE
Doctor Heinrich Shnitzer.
(beat)
We believe he stole our sample and
is hiding out somewhere on the east
side.

Stanley scoffs.

STANLEY
So he takes out a few hippies.
(beat)
Great, he did the world a service.

The lieutenant stands and walks towards the detective,
growing increasingly agitated.

MAURICE
Or say he might weaponize it,
filling the balloons of the Macy's
day parade!
(beat)
The casualties would be
catastrophic!!

Maurice collects himself.

MAURICE (CONT'D)
You need to find that stolen
sample, destroy whatever work has
been done, and secure the threat
before I come back.

STANLEY
I prefer you **don't** come back!

Maurice throws his arm around Stan.

MAURICE
You've not let me down yet.
(beat)
Don't start now.

Maurice exits.

LUCILE
What a free spirit!

Stan resets, the bass plays, he cleans up the drinks off his desk, sits back down. Rubs his head.

Then she enters. A sultry vixen, big hair, red dress, high heels. Her name: AVA SHNITZER

She walks with a noticeable wobble in her step, only on a single side.

Ava lets herself into the office.

Lucile turns and watches her pass.

LUCILE (CONT'D)
Bombshell incoming, Mr. C.

Stan looks up from having his head in his hands. His eyes go wide just as Ava hides her wobble by grabbing on to the back of the chair.

Ava attempts to fix her hair and hit a sexy pose, while holding on to the chair.

STANLEY
(measured)
Do you need to sit down?

Ava laughs and sits.

AVA
Do I entice you.

Stan scoffs.

STANLEY
Uhh. Yeah.
(beat)
Yes. Yes. Yes you do.

Stanley collects himself.

STANLEY (CONT'D)
But, to what do I owe the pleasure?

AVA
I believe you owe me a drink,
Stanley C. Clarke.

STANLEY
Well, you've got me at a
disadvantage, miss...

AVA
Shnitzer.
(beat)
Ava. Shnitzer.

Stan shakes his fist and leans down to the side, profile of Miss Ava.

STANLEY
The Germans!

He then leverages his current position to grab the glasses and bourbon. He rises and sets it all on the table.

He speaks as he pours:

STANLEY (CONT'D)
So, how your father doing.

Ava takes the glass.

AVA
He needs...
(beat)
Time.

STANLEY
Sorry honey, I'm on a bit of a tight schedule.

Ava hits her most seductive pouty pose.

AVA
I'm told to delay you by any means necessary.

Ava stands, her legs buckle and she is unable to stand still. She wobbles towards the edge of the desk, Stan rises out of his seat to catch Ava before she falls.

AVA (CONT'D)
Get off me!

Ava pushes herself away while standing on the heels. She stands tall.

Then.

She pulls the heels off and shrinks a good few inches.

AVA (CONT'D)
A degree in physics and I still can't figure these things out.

STANLEY

You wore them well and that's what counts.

Ava gives a good belly laugh. She begins gesturing with her heels.

AVA

You have to give my father time.

(beat)

You don't understand.

(beat)

My father's intentions with the plague are benign.

STANLEY

Cancer?

AVA

Cure!

(beat)

Your government lies to you.

(beat)

They wish to weaponize it!

(beat)

My father wants to build a vaccine.

(beat)

Nothing more.

STANLEY

But he stole it, right?

(beat)

Because I need that!

(beat)

Or it's my ass!

AVA

Your ass or hundreds of millions dead?

Ava creates a map with her shoes.

AVA (CONT'D)

It could go from New York...

(beat)

All the way...

(beat)

To San Francisco.

STANLEY

Well, I like my ass.

AVA

Ugh... Idiot.

Ava storms off, heels in hand. She pauses at the stage's end and turns back, points a heel at Stan:

AVA (CONT'D)
Do not interfere, Stanley C.
Clarke.
(beat)
For your own good.

Ava exits.

LUCILE
That went well.

Stan rubs his brow then grabs his glass off his desk and downs the drink.

He sighs and heads down left of stage.

All attention is on Stan.

He speaks to the audience.

STANLEY
The plague?
(beat)
Isn't that, like, history stuff?
(beat)
Sure, the Lieutenant gives me
steady work.
(beat)
And that Ava sure looked good in
those heels.
(beat)
But a guys gotta get paid, so I'm
off to find that dirty kraut.

Stan exits the stage.

INTERLUDE

BASS plays.

Lucile sits clacking at her typewriter.

A FRAIL MAN enters. His coke-bottle glasses and pronounced hunch pair nicely with his trench coat. He's holding a small POSTAL-WRAPPED PACKAGE.

His stride is measured if not a little labored. As he steps on stage, he leans in to Lucile.

MAN

I'm not here, and **this** is not a thing.

He enters the office. And as Lucile speaks, the man places the package on Stan's desk and hides behind the bass player:

LUCILE

They don't pay me to see anything but this typewriter, honey.

Stan returns.

STANLEY

Do you know how many Shnitzers there are on the east side?

LUCILE

(nonplussed)
A billion, Mr. C?

STANLEY

At least!

Stan enters his office and throws his jacket over the chair as he notices the package.

STANLEY (CONT'D)

Lucile! Did anyone come in while I was out?

LUCILE

Oh honey, you only pay me to see these keys.

(beat)

Now if you want to increase the circumference of my view...

(beat)

That'll cost ya!

STANLEY

Initiative, Lucile! Initiative!

Lucile goes back to clacking away at her typewriter.

Stan opens the package after fully scrutinizing the wrapping.

He holds a vial filled with green liquid up by his forehead to get a real good look at the contents.

STANLEY (CONT'D)

(sotto)

The Germans...

The man shifts out from behind the bass player holding a PISTOL.

MAN

I'm afraid you're correct Herr Clarke!

STANLEY

Doctor Shnitzer!

SHNITZER

One in the same!

LUCILE

Ooh sounds like you've got a German in there, Mr. C!

STANLEY

Yeah.

(to Lucile)

Unfortunately!

SHNITZER

I must say, Stanley.

(beat)

I'm disappointed in your institutionalized distrust of the German people.

(beat)

We are not all bad.

(beat)

Some of us want to do great good!

STANLEY

By stealing the plague?!

SHNITZER

By creating a cure!

STANLEY

And pointing a gun at me?!!

SHNITZER

Formalities, Mr. Clarke.

(beat)

I'm a wanted man, my face is in every post office.

(beat)

I need you to send this vial to Geneva. To people who care!

STANLEY

Would now be a weird time for me to reach for my gun?

The Lieutenant enters whistling as Lucile begins to type and the bass fills in the bottom end.

He hops on stage and leans down to Lucile.

MAURICE

Don't work too hard, Lucile.

(beat)

I know for a fact he's not paying you enough.

(beat)

Mind if I head in?

LUCILE

You wouldn't listen if I said no...

Maurice chuckles and walks in.

He surveys the scene. From his perspective, he sees a relatively tense Stan and the back of Dr. Shnitzer.

He doesn't see the gun.

MAURICE

Ah! Found the Kraut ahead of schedule!

Maurice claps the shoulders of Shnitzer.

MAURICE (CONT'D)

It's a home-by-five kind of day!

Maurice looks down and sees the gun, he recoils and pulls his own.

MAURICE (CONT'D)

Sweet Jesus!

Stanley motions to Dr. Shnitzer.

STANLEY

This nice German says he only stole the plague from you to make a **cure**.

(beat)

Isn't that right, Doctor?

The Doctor nods.

SHNITZER

Yes, to save the lives of billions!

MAURICE

That's very much the problem!

(beat)

(MORE)

MAURICE (CONT'D)
There's too. Many. Of. Us.
(beat)
We can't feed everyone.
(beat)
We're making quite a mess of this planet.
(beat)
And there's so. Many. Imbeciles.

STANLEY
Hey, I take offense to that!

MAURICE
(to Stanley)
Quiet you. You'll be getting your money.

Stanley coos at the though.

MAURICE (CONT'D)
We need to limit the population to survive.
(beat)
Yes Doctor, for the greater good.

SHNITZER
We have a different word for that where I come from.
(beat)
Genocide.
(beat)
What makes you think you deserve to decide? Who lives, who dies.

MAURICE
I leave that up to my superiors in the U.S. Government.
(beat)
Specifically, the department of Happy Live Long Time.

STANLEY
And you're saying I need to leave the schoolyard?

SHNITZER
Schoolyard, yes think of the **children!**

MAURICE
The fit will survive.

SHNITZER
And the rest?

MAURICE

The plague!

(beat)

It'll replace sugar. We've been
using it for years, but it just.
Takes. Too. Long!

SHNITZER

You fiend!

(beat)

The epidemics in diabetes. Heart
disease. Obesity!

(beat)

It is all you.

(beat)

My god.

MAURICE

Yes, but the plague is far more
efficient!

(beat)

Our species will strengthen and
thrive.

(beat)

The casualties are a necessary cost
to survival.

SHNITZER

One government should not dictate
the future.

Doctor Shnitzer raises his gun.

SHNITZER (CONT'D)

I cannot allow this injustice to
continue!

Shnitzer shoots and Stanley instinctively pushes the Doctor
so his shot lands off target. The bullet hits Maurice in the
shoulder. The Doctor falls over the desk.

Maurice lists backwards slightly, then laughs.

MAURICE

Stan...

(beat)

You just saved me a mountain of
paperwork.

Maurice shoots Shnitzer square in the chest. Leaving Shnitzer
enough time to brace on the desk and deliver one hell of a
last line.

SHNITZER
Oh, you asshole.

He looks to Stanley.

SHNITZER (CONT'D)
You idiot.

He dies and drapes over the desk.

Stanley looks up at Maurice. Maurice holsters his weapon.

MAURICE
I'll be needing that cure.

STANLEY
I've been through a lot today, how
about I keep it?
(beat)
As part of payment.

MAURICE
To get paid, you'll need to give me
that vial, Stan.

STANLEY
Okay.
(beat)
Why don't we split it?

Maurice pulls his gun and points it at Stan.

MAURICE
You wouldn't be much more
paperwork.

Stan immediately throws his hands over his head, the vial
flies over to Maurice. Maurice catches it easily and pockets
it.

MAURICE (CONT'D)
You've made Uncle Sam a happy man
today.

STANLEY
(sarcastic)
Do I get a parade?

Maurice hoists Shnitzer over his shoulder and begins to walk
off. He turns back to look at Stanley.

MAURICE
You know what happens when you open
your mouth.

Stan beams a nervous smile and nods. Maurice smiles and slaps a wad of cash on the desk.

MAURICE (CONT'D)
This should pay the bills.
(beat)
The department of Happy Live Long
Time will be in touch.

Maurice turns and leaves. As he passes Lucile:

MAURICE (CONT'D)
What do you see, Lucile?

LUCILE
Just these keys, Lieutenant.

MAURICE
That's a girl.

Maurice exits.

Lucile starts typing and the bass begins again.

Stanley shakes his head, grabs his jacket.

He grabs the money.

Holds it in his hand and pockets the money.

STANLEY
Well Lucile, there's a fifty
percent chance I just saved the
human race.

Lucile balks.

LUCILE
Oh, you think highly of the
Lieutenant!

Lucile turns to look at Stan. The first time in the entire play.

LUCILE (CONT'D)
I'll give it a solid twelve
percent.

STANLEY
Twelve percent a hero?
(beat)
I can live with that.
(beat)
Lock it up tight, would ya?

Stanley exits.

Lucile types just a few more clacks. Then pauses.

The BASS stops.

LUCILE

Another day, another dance through
the minefield...

BASS picks up. Plays to blackout.